IT & Product Management Club
IIM Lucknow, Noida campus

PIVOT '26

Round 1 Case Document

LIFE AFTER THE BAN

Can Dream11 keep 300 million sports fans coming back once the prize is gone?

Aug 2025
India bans real-money gaming

Dec 2025
Free-to-play and second-screen

Aug 2026
Dream11 declares the pivot complete

Now
Your turn: will it work, and what would you change?

Submissions close 10 October 2026, 11:59 PM

Campus round: 25 October 2026, IIM Lucknow, Noida Prize pool ₹33,000

Hosted on unstop

Independent case built from public sources, current to 21 September 2026. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Dream Sports, Dream11 or FanCode.

Section 01

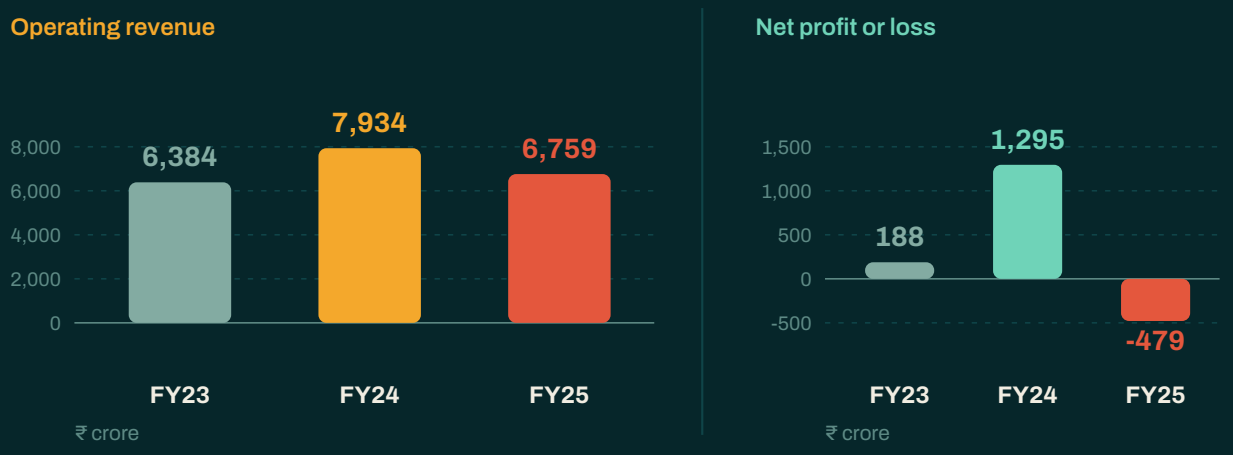
The business that was

For seventeen years, Dream11 sold one thing: the chance to win money on sport. By the time Parliament made that illegal, the business was already shrinking.

Founded in Mumbai in 2008 by Harsh Jain and Bhavit Sheth, Dream11 let fans build fantasy teams from real players and score points on their real-world performance. Paid contests, with entry fees and cash prizes, drove the business, and Dream11 became the face of Indian cricket sponsorship. Its parent, Dream Sports, was last valued at about $8 billion in 2021.

The decline started before the ban

Dream Sports group results, financial years ending March. FY26, the first year of the ban, is not yet public.



The ban

Parliament passed the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act on 21 August 2025 and it received presidential assent the next day. It bans offering, operating or facilitating any online game played for money, with penalties of up to three years in prison, a fine of up to ₹1 crore, or both. The Act was only notified into force on 1 May 2026.

Dream11's response

- Paused every paid contest on 21 August 2025, the day the Bill passed and eight months before the law took effect. CEO Harsh Jain said paid contests had produced roughly 95% of revenue and all of the profit.
- Chose not to challenge the law, unlike A23's parent Head Digital Works, which went to court.
- Told the BCCI it could not continue as lead sponsor of the Indian cricket team, walking away from a deal worth close to $44 million over 2023 to 2026. It later exited IPL team jerseys too.

Section 02

Where the law stands

Two separate court matters sit behind this case, and they point in different directions.

The ban itself: still open

Head Digital Works v Union of India challenges whether Parliament can ban online money games at all. It is pending before a three-judge bench led by the Chief Justice, last listed for 5 August 2026 with no ruling reported. If it succeeds, paid fantasy could return.

The tax: already decided

On 27 May 2026 the Supreme Court held that real-money games, fantasy sports included, count as betting for tax. 28% GST applies to the full value of player deposits, not just the platform's commission, reviving demands the industry puts near ₹2.5 lakh crore.

> **What this means for you.** Even in the best case for the industry, the economics Dream11 walked away from do not simply come back. Any recommendation that assumes a return to paid contests has to survive a 28% tax on deposits.

The Dream Sports family after the split

In December 2025 Dream Sports broke itself into eight independent units. Several already do part of what Dream11 now says it will become.

Dream11
The pivoting app

FanCode
Live sports streaming, 160M+ users

DreamSetGo
Sports travel and experiences

Dream Cricket
Mobile cricket game

Dream Sports AI
AI products, incl. Dream Play

Dream Money
Broking and wealth

Dream Horizon
Open-source tech

Foundation
Philanthropy

Worth noticing: FanCode already streams La Liga, Formula 1, MotoGP and global cricket on subscriptions and match passes. Dream11's new direction includes live streaming too.

Section 03

One year of pivoting

Dream11 did not pivot once. It tried several directions in quick succession, then declared a destination in August 2026.

21 August 2025
All paid contests shut, the day the Bill passes. Dream11 commits to complying.

September 2025
Relaunches free-to-play, earning from ads and branded contests. About 10 million daily active users, roughly 70% aged 18 to 35. Swiggy, Astrotalk and Tata Neu advertise.

4 December 2025
Announces a "second-screen" pivot: creator-led watch-alongs, live reactions and free-to-play fantasy. Dream Money broking and overseas games follow.

December 2025
Dream Sports splits into eight independent units. Dream11's 700 staff are redistributed across them and about 15% leave.

February 2026
Says watch-alongs drew 30 million fans in two months, its only published engagement figure since the ban. It still describes its base as 250 million users.

May 2026
The Act is notified into force on 1 May. On 27 May the Supreme Court rules that fantasy sports count as betting for tax, at 28% GST on deposits.

27 August 2026
CEO Vaibhav Kokal announces the pivot is complete. All prizes go, including free fantasy. Dream11 is now an AI-first, global, multi-sport engagement platform for, it says, 300 million users.

300M
Users claimed in Aug 2026. It still said 250M in Feb 2026

~95%
Share of revenue that came from paid contests

30M
Fans reached by watch-alongs in their first two months

Section 04

The fight for a fan's attention

With money gone, Dream11 is no longer competing for a fan's wallet. It is competing for their attention on match day, against apps they already open.

Where fans already go	What they go there for	Why it matters to Dream11
JioHotstar	Watching major cricket live, including the IPL	The default screen during a match; Dream11 must be the second one
Cricbuzz, ESPNcricinfo	Live scores, stats and ball-by-ball commentary	Dream11's new stats and commentary features land directly here
FanCode	Streaming other sports on passes and subscriptions	A sister company, already doing live streaming
YouTube, Instagram, X	Highlights, memes, creators and live reactions	Where the conversation around a match actually happens
Offshore betting apps	Money games that are illegal in India	Fans who wanted stakes may drift to unregulated platforms

Three tensions at the heart of the case

01

The reason to open the app was the prize.

Fantasy sport made watching a match personal because you had something riding on it. Take away the money, and you need a new reason to open Dream11 today rather than tomorrow.

02

Two apps, one parent.

Dream11's new direction overlaps with FanCode. Should they compete, merge, or split the job cleanly?

03

The ground may move, but not all the way back.

The challenge to the ban is still pending. Even if it succeeds, the May 2026 GST ruling taxes 28% of every rupee deposited, so the old economics may not return.

Section 05

Your task

Your role. You have just joined Dream11 as Head of Product, a month after the pivot was declared complete. The CEO wants a clear-eyed answer: **will this pivot work, and what would you change?** Answer the four questions below, in order.

1

Diagnose

Who are the fans still opening Dream11 without prizes, and who left? Segment them by behaviour, not demographics, and explain what each group actually wants from the app now.

2

Judge the pivot

Is a "global sports engagement platform" the right destination? Keep it, sharpen it or replace it, and say why. Define Dream11's job relative to FanCode, so the two are not fighting for the same fan.

3

Build the next 12 months

Design the core loop that brings a fan back on every match day without money on the line. Sequence what ships, and name what you deliberately will not build.

4

Make it pay

Show how Dream11 earns money without prizes. Define one north-star metric and three or four supporting metrics, with targets at 6 and 12 months, and the signal that would tell you within 90 days that you are wrong.

Stress test your answer

Suppose the Supreme Court strikes down the ban next year. Paid fantasy becomes legal again, but 28% GST still applies to every rupee deposited. Does your strategy hold, or would Dream11 go back? One slide or the appendix.

There is no single right answer. We are judging the quality of your reasoning, not which direction you choose.

Section 06

What we expect

Submit one PDF on Unstop by 11:59 PM on 10 October 2026.

Item	Requirement
Main deck	Up to 8 slides, not counting the cover
Appendix	Up to 3 pages. Must list your sources and disclose any AI tools you used
File	One PDF, maximum 25 MB, named TeamName_R1.pdf
Video (optional)	A 2-minute walkthrough; put an unlisted YouTube or Drive link on your cover slide

Strong submissions

- Commit to one direction and defend it against the obvious alternatives
- Back every claim with evidence, and cite it
- Talk to real fans: ten good interviews beat a survey no one designed
- Treat FanCode as part of the answer, not an afterthought
- Tie every metric to the strategy, with numbers and dates

What costs marks

- Listing every option without choosing one
- Numbers with no source, or assumptions left unstated
- "Use AI to personalise" with no explanation of what changes for the fan
- Revenue ideas that bring back money contests in disguise, which are illegal
- A deck that needs a presenter to make sense

How to research this case

- **Use the app.** Download Dream11 and FanCode and spend a match day in both.
- **Primary research.** Interview people who played paid contests and ask what they do now. Put your method and sample size in the appendix.
- **Public sources.** App store reviews and ratings, Dream Sports' announcements, the founders' posts, and the reporting listed on the last page.
- **This case is current to 21 September 2026.** Anything announced after that is fair game. Account for it and cite it.
- **State your assumptions** wherever the public data runs out. An unstated assumption costs you more than a missing number.

Section 07

Judging, dates and contact

Criterion	Weight	What earns marks
Product thinking and solution quality	25%	A clear verdict on the pivot, with honest reasons the alternatives lose (Q2)
Problem understanding and user insight	20%	Fan segments defined by behaviour and grounded in evidence (Q1)
Feasibility and prioritisation	20%	A sequenced roadmap with a real core loop and named cuts (Q3)
Business impact and success metrics	20%	A legal revenue model, targets, and a 90-day signal that could prove you wrong (Q4)
Structure, clarity and presentation	15%	A deck a busy CEO could follow in five minutes

Key dates

10 Oct
Round 1 and registrations close

16 Oct
Top 10 announced

23 Oct
Final decks due, 6:00 PM

25 Oct
Campus round, Noida

Rules in brief

- Work must be original. Plagiarism means disqualification.
- AI tools are allowed for research and drafting but must be disclosed in the appendix.
- Teams are locked once Round 1 is submitted. Late or non-compliant submissions will not be reviewed.
- Travel and stay for the campus round are arranged and paid for by participating teams.
- Full terms are on the Unstop listing, and the judges' decision is final.

Questions? Get in touch

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Appendix

Sources

All facts in this case come from the public reporting below, accessed up to 21 September 2026.

Dream11 completes pivot to a global sports engagement platform
exchange4media, 27 Aug 2026
https://www.exchange4media.com/industry-briefing-news/dream11-completes-pivot-to-a-global-sports-engagement-platform-157698.html

Dream11 completes pivot, no longer a gaming app
Economic Times via inkl, Aug 2026
https://www.inkl.com/news/dream11-completes-pivot-from-fantasy-sports-to-global-sports-engagement-platform-drops-all-real-money-contests

Dream11 parent slips into loss in FY25 on reverse flipping cost
Inc42, Feb 2026
https://inc42.com/buzz/dream11-parent-slips-into-loss-in-fy25-on-reverse-flipping-cost/

Dream Sports restructures business as over 100 executives exit
Entrackr, 2026
https://entrackr.com/news/dream-sports-restructures-business-as-over-100-executives-exit-11204947

Head Digital Works v Union of India: challenge to the Online Gaming Act, 2025
Supreme Court Observer
https://www.scobserver.in/cases/challenge-to-the-promotion-and-regulation-of-online-gaming-act-2025/

Online Gaming Act 2025 and the Supreme Court's 27 May GST verdict
Niyam, Jun 2026
https://niyam.ai/blog/online-gaming-act-sc-verdict

Dream11 shifts strategy following India's real-money gaming ban
Outlook Respawn, Sep 2025
https://respawn.outlookindia.com/gaming/gaming-news/dream11-shifts-strategy-following-indias-real-money-gaming-ban

Dream11 pivots to free-to-play model with ads
Storyboard18, Sep 2025
https://www.storyboard18.com/gaming-news/dream11-pivots-to-free-to-play-model-with-ads-after-real-money-gaming-ban-81390.htm

Dream11 pauses paid contests; Dream Sports shifts focus to FanCode, DreamSetGo
Storyboard18, Aug 2025
https://storyboard18.com/gaming-news/dream11-pauses-paid-contests-dream-sports-shifts-focus-to-fancode-dreamsetgo-79372.htm

Dream11 pivots from gaming to a sports entertainment platform
exchange4media, 4 Dec 2025
https://www.exchange4media.com/digital-news/dream11-pivots-from-gaming-to-a-sports-entertainment-platform-149947.html

Rajasthan Royals captaincy reveal on Dream11 (watch-along engagement)
Dream Sports, Feb 2026
https://dreamsports.group/media-and-blog/royals-reset-rajasthan-royals-to-announce-captain-live-exclusive-on-dream11

A23 parent Head Digital Works moves Karnataka HC against the gaming law
Business Standard, Aug 2025
https://www.business-standard.com/companies/news/head-digital-works-challenges-online-gaming-law-karnataka-hc-125082800629_1.html

Dream11 company profile, including the December 2025 restructuring
CB Insights, 2026
https://www.cbinsights.com/company/dream11